

How to Get Into ox-odt

A Complete Setup, Configuration, and Styling Guide

kishore

<2026-08-04 Tue>

Table of Contents

- [1. Important Links & Pre-requisites](#)
 - [1.1. Important Links](#)
 - [1.2. Pre-requisites](#)
- [2. Setup & Installation](#)
 - [2.1. Installing the Enhanced Version \(Elpaca\)](#)
- [3. Useful Commands & Workflow](#)
- [4. ODT Specific Export Settings](#)
 - [4.1. Explanation of Core Options](#)
- [5. Applying Custom Styles](#)
 - [5.1. 1. Using a LibreOffice Template \(.ott\)](#)
 - [5.2. 2. Using Inline ``odt\_extrastyles``](#)
 - [5.2.1. Usage Examples:](#)
 - [5.2.1.1. Page Breaks](#)
 - [5.2.1.2. Info / Callout Box](#)
 - [5.2.1.3. Warning / Alert Box](#)
 - [5.2.1.4. Text Highlighting](#)
- [6. Tables, Images, Labels & Captions](#)

Important Links & Pre-requisites

Important Links

- [Official Org Mode ODT Export Manual](#)
- [Enhanced ox-odt Repository \(kjambunathan\)](#)
- [ox-odt GitHub Discussions](#)

Pre-requisites

- **zip / unzip**: Required by Emacs to pack/unpack OpenDocument archives.
- **LibreOffice Writer**: Required for viewing output and creating/modifying .ott template files.

Setup & Installation

There are two versions of ox-odt:

1. **Built-in ox-odt:** Comes bundled with stock Emacs/Org mode.
2. **Enhanced ox-odt:** Forked and maintained by the original author with additional features and bug fixes.

Installing the Enhanced Version (Elpaca)

[Installation Manual](#)

Add the following block to your Emacs configuration:

```
(elpaca (ox-odt :host github
               :repo "kjambunathan/org-mode-ox-odt"
               :files ("lisp/ox-odt.el"
                      "lisp/ox-ods.el"
                      "lisp/odt.el"
                      "etc"
                      "docs"
                      "contrib/odt/LibreOffice")))
```

Useful Commands & Workflow

Reference: [ODT Export Commands Manual](#)

Shortcut	Command / Function	Description
C-c C-e o o	org-odt-export-to-odt	Export current buffer to .odt and open it
C-c C-e o O	org-odt-export-to-odt	Export and convert directly to PDF/DOCX
C-c C-e # odt RET	Template Insertion	Insert empty ODT export option headers into buffer

ODT Specific Export Settings

Reference: [ODT Specific Settings Manual](#)

Header options inserted into the top of your document:

```
#+TITLE: My Document Title
#+SUBTITLE: Subtitle or Description
#+AUTHOR: kishore
#+KEYWORDS: emacs org-mode odt export
#+OPTIONS: toc:t num:t H:6

# ODT Directives
#+ODT_PREFERRED_OUTPUT_FORMAT: pdf
#+ODT_STYLES_FILE: "../template.ott"
#+ODT_EXTRA_STYLES: ...
#+ODT_EXTRA_IMAGES: ...
```

```
#+ODT_EXTRA_AUTOMATIC_STYLES: ...  
#+ODT_MASTER_STYLES: ...  
#+ODT_CONTENT_TEMPLATE_FILE: ...  
#+ODT_AUTOMATIC_STYLES: ...
```

Explanation of Core Options

`toc:t`

Generates a Table of Contents (`toc:nil` to disable).

`num:t`

Numbers section headings automatically (`num:nil` for unnumbered).

`H:6`

Sets headline export depth to 6. **Crucial:** By default, Org mode turns levels deeper than 3 into bullet lists. Setting `H:6` forces levels 1–6 to render as real headings.

`#+ODT_PREFERRED_OUTPUT_FORMAT: pdf`

Automatically invokes LibreOffice in the background to convert ``odt`` into ``pdf`` (or ``docx``, ``doc``, ``rtf``).

Applying Custom Styles

Reference: [Applying Custom Styles Manual](#)

1. Using a LibreOffice Template (.ott)

The cleanest approach for document-wide custom styles:

```
#+ODT_STYLES_FILE: "/path/to/example.ott"
```

2. Using Inline ``odtextrastyles``

You can define XML style blocks directly inside your Org document and apply them to elements.

Usage Examples:

Page Breaks

Use the macro anywhere in your text to force a new page:

```
{{{pagebreak}}}
```

Info / Callout Box

Note: This is an important info box with a blue accent line.

Warning / Alert Box

Warning: This is a caution block for critical warnings.

Text Highlighting

Highlight inline text using ODT span tags:

This is normal text, but this text is highlighted in yellow.

Tables, Images, Labels & Captions

Tables in ODT export

Custom table formatting, column widths, and grid styling.

Images in ODT export

Inline image sizing, alignment, and format conversions.

Labels and captions in ODT export

Cross-referencing figures, equations, and tables.